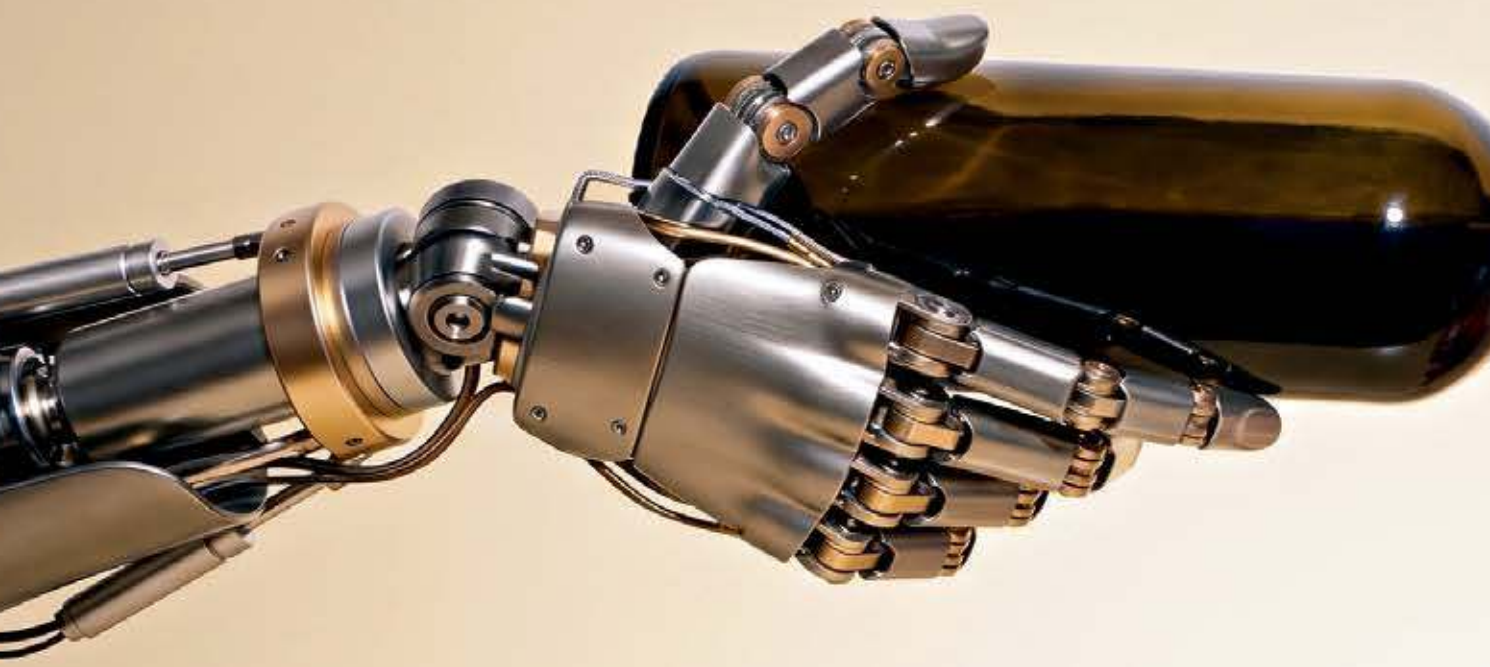
WINE
TREND



The Third Rule of Robotics by Isaac Asimov states that... I'd dive deeper but, you know what I'm getting at? The man knew something about sentience and machines. Today, standing on the precipice of this evolutionary cliff, unsure whether we shall fall or fly, the leap has already begun.

AI is woven into our daily drama—from smarter shopping to autonomous driving, writing an essay to writing code, it's the quotidian crutch that had no gestation period whatsoever! But like all dependencies, this too comes with questions, and fears. In my field, service and hospitality, AI can organise and reorder with astronomical precision, build bar programmes balanced down to their pH. Then, it can sell it all with effortless prose. A human would need decades of experience to exhibit similar levels of confidence. So, is the era of pompous sommeliers with their tootin' tastevins over? Are we done enduring cocky bartenders who fashion themselves as scientists? In spite of my tilted tone, I thought it best to congregate and consult folks of the trade: Ai—challenger, or chum?

Kicking it off was Hyeon, a seasoned internationally-acclaimed beverage expert who felt that AI can be, "...critical for both wine programmes and perishable cocktail ingredients. It's already happening." This thought was resonated by Supradeep Dey, head mixologist for Atelier House hospitality with outlets in Dubai and India, who added that, "it can help take the repetitive tasks off our hands allowing us to focus more on genuine guest engagement." Pratik Angre, working as a wine professional in Dubai, added that AI can go further, "...creating even marketing campaigns, all within minutes." Sahil Misra, Global Brand Ambassador and Head of Exports for Sula Vineyards, rebutted with: "It's not just consumption patterns, there is also discovery, emotion, and context."

Already, it seemed humans were making a case for AI. Where does it leave us then? Devi Singh, an ace bartender with a wicked sense of humour, had the answer. "It's difficult to replace the human touch. People go out for a drink, but also for service, vibe, and interaction. Bartenders cannot be fully replaced, neither the floor manpower. AI can't run bars end-to-end like people."

We do like interactive service. In a new city, a bar stool provides access to a drink-maker and a local guide who is also part agony uncle/aunt/'insert current pronoun'. Dey agrees: "I sit at the bar to order but also to feel comfortable, heard, and connected after a long day." Suryaveer Singh, a sommelier, and founder of the Hyderabad Wine Society, set